RESILIENCE & CONNECTION

Handling setbacks, staying steady under pressure, and keeping the relationships that carry people through hard times.

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GUIDE / VERIFY: General wellness information, not mental-health treatment. **If you are in crisis or thinking about suicide, call or text 988** (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, 24 hours). If someone is in immediate danger, call 911.

1. WHAT RESILIENCE IS

Resilience is the ability to adapt to hard things (loss, illness, disaster, money trouble) and keep functioning. It isn't a trait you have or don't: it is built from habits and relationships, and anyone can strengthen it. Resilient people still feel grief, fear and anger. They just find ways to keep going.

2. FOUR AREAS TO BUILD

AREA	WHAT HELPS
Connection	Close relationships with family and friends; a community (faith group, club, neighbors, volunteers). People who have support recover better from almost everything.
Wellness	Sleep, movement, regular meals and limiting alcohol and other drugs. A tired, hungry body makes everything feel worse. *(WL-01 to WL-06)*
Healthy thinking	Keep things in perspective ("this is hard, and it won't last forever"); accept what you can't change; look for what you can do next; learn from what happened before.
Meaning	Helping others, working toward goals, and acting on what matters to you give a sense of purpose that steadies people through hard times.

3. STAYING CONNECTED

Loneliness and isolation are linked to higher risks of heart disease, stroke, depression, anxiety and dementia. Connection is protective, and it can be built on purpose:

- Reach out to one person each day: a call, a text, a visit.
- Put regular time with friends and family on the calendar.
- Join something: a class, a team, a faith community, a club.
- Volunteer. Helping others is one of the strongest ways to feel connected.
- Get to know your neighbors. In an emergency, they are the first people who can help, and who need help.
- Check on people who live alone, especially older adults, during storms, heat waves and outages.
- Put the phone down when you're with people.
- Say yes to invitations, even when it's easier not to.

4. AFTER SOMETHING HARD HAPPENS

- Strong reactions are normal: trouble sleeping, irritability, sadness, replaying events. They usually ease over weeks.
- Keep routines where you can: meals, sleep, school, work.
- Talk about it with people you trust, when you're ready.
- Children take cues from adults: stay calm, answer questions simply and honestly, and keep them close.

- Limit how much news and how many images of the event you take in.
- Get help if reactions don't ease, or get worse, after a few weeks.

HELP LINES: 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline: call or text **988**. Disaster Distress Helpline: call or text **1-800-985-5990**. Both are free, confidential and open 24 hours.

5. MY SUPPORT NETWORK

NAME	PHONE	WHAT THEY HELP WITH (TALKING, RIDES, CHILDCARE, CHECKING ON ME...)

People I'll check on in an emergency	
Groups I belong to or want to join	
Something that has gotten me through before	

SOURCES / FURTHER REFERENCE

1. American Psychological Association: Building Your Resilience. apa.org/topics/resilience
2. U.S. Surgeon General: Our Epidemic of Loneliness and Isolation (advisory, 2023). hhs.gov/surgeongeneral
3. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention: Social Connection; Coping with a Disaster or Traumatic Event. cdc.gov
4. SAMHSA: Disaster Distress Helpline. samhsa.gov/find-help/disaster-distress-helpline 988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline. 988lifeline.org

IMPORTANT: If reactions to a hard event last or get worse, a counselor, doctor or faith leader can help. Asking for help is a resilient thing to do.